

3/25/88

To: BO Ad staff
From: MN
Re: Tandy's Deskmate strategy

I've synopsized my notes from Tandy's 3/24/88 press briefing:

Tandy is giving free licenses to software developers to adapt their software to the Deskmate user interface. This will allow software aimed at the home and small-business market to have a common command set--you learn one you learn them all no matter who sells it. In short, Tandy is trying to make Deskmate the poor man's Windows or Presentation Manager.

Tandy believes that making computers easier to use for the home and small-business users, via a common interface, will increase demand for low-end computers. Juge claimed that this low-end market has the potential to be "three times bigger than the Fortune 1000 market."

So far, Tandy is working with only a few select companies--all big names in the low-end market: Electronic Arts, Software Publishing, Symantec, Intuit, Activision, and Sierra On-Line. Scott Cook of Intuit said that he knew of ten other large software vendors waiting in the wings to adopt the Deskmate standard. Juge hinted that a major network vendor has all but signed an agreement.

Interesting quotes: "It would be a fatal error for anyone targeting the education market not to write under Deskmate," Kevin Conway, Software Publishing.

"The personal computer will be the VCR of 1989 and 1990...you won't be able to exist without one," Kevin Conway

"I threw away eight month's of work to go with Deskmate," Mike Branum, Sierra On-Line

"Familiarity is ease of use," Scott Cook, Intuit.

"Tandy has gotten out of the software applications business and into the [software] environment business," Scott Cutler, Tandy.

It's difficult to say what this means to BO Micro. Certainly Tandy is lining up important support among vendors targeting the same market that we are. If a standard for the low-end market is accepted by the vendors and users, it will either broaden our potential audience or kill it--if computers become too easy to use, who needs a magazine?

The way around the latter might be to become strictly product oriented, but I prefer to discuss these possibilities later. For now, Tandy's profile is rising, and for the time being that can only help us.

Tandy also handed out invitations to an April 21 product announcement, I assume for its PS/2 clone. I suggest a strategy session after that announcement.



Donna La Michèle - Software Merchandise
Scott Cuthbert

Designate
Consistent look & feel
Home - Small Business

Apple lawsuit
Last script

betwixt shall p designate

Must work on software quickly
Fit in 256K - remain compatible
Easier to use than ever before

Software Publishing
Sierra Online
Inhibit

Letting the market
on other

Use - cost-free license
make people buy
expand the market
3 times sales as
for 2000 1000 market

Use programs the same way

Mike Brennan

Prod. in Designate line through all channels
run on all PC compatibles

MUSIC - 1 manuscript
2 prg. games

2-4 people networks

Designate supports all major resolutions

E-mail
Tandy/Link

Environment Business - NOT software application
Next: Designate for 3rd party
(can't make changes without messing up people)

Scott Cuthbert - Inhibit

Familiarity is ease of use
Home - small business



Kevin Conway - Sales Proliferation
Tandy being channel of Distrib
personnel as opposed to workstation
Tandy will broaden market
for everyone - VCR of 1989 or 1990
won't be able to exist what are

White papers on...
- Fatal error
for anyone reports
education not to
write under distribute

Mike Braugum - Some
End use must see consistency
Spent year with w.p.
Threw away \$1000 worth to go w/distribute
No new software for new hardware

10 big names in house - Scott Cook